Cinematography: Camera Placement/Movement

# Speed of the Shot

Action can be shot at any frame rate, but to reproduce the normal speed of the action on-screen, the device that shows us the movie must play it back at the same rate in which it was shot. The number of frames shot and projected per second was standardized at 24 frames per second (fps) in the late 1920s. In recent years, some filmmakers have experimented with higher camera and projector frame rates in an effort to produce sharper images and a more precise reproduction of movement.

## Slow Motion

Deviations from normal speed are accomplished by altering frame rate during the production phase. This means that directors and cinematographers must decide in advance which shots will appear as fast or slow motion when they are projected to an audience. Slow motion is achieved by filming at a higher frame rate. For example, to create a shot where the action happens at half of normal speed, the camera frame rate must be doubled to 48 fps, so that when the shot is played back at 24 fps, it will take up twice the screen time. Slow motion tends to make movement appear more graceful, which makes it useful for a number of applications. It can suggest a character's heightened awareness, impart significance to an action that might otherwise be interpreted as mundane, lend an ironic elegance to violence, or suspend viewers in a moment that would normally be fleeting, such as a kiss . . . or an explosion.

Slow motion tends to make movement appear more graceful and elegant, which may explain the ubiquity of the "power-walk" shot featuring a group of characters walking shoulder to shoulder in slow motion toward the camera to express their confidence and cool. Introduced to great effect in films such as Stanley Kubrick's *A Clockwork Orange* (1971).

***A Clockwork Orange* (Stanley Kubrick, 1971)**

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The technique has become a cliché and is regularly parodied in comedies such as Phil Lord and Christopher Miller's *21 Jump Street* (2012).

***21 Jump Street* (Phil Lord and Christopher Miller, 2012)**

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## Fast Motion

Fast motion is achieved by filming at a lower frame rate. To make action on-screen appear

twice as fast as it actually occurred, the cinematographer would shoot it at 12 fps so that when it is projected at 24 fps, that same action will take only half as much screen time as it took in real time. Speeding up the way we humans move can make our actions look ridiculous, and so fast motion is often used for comic effect.